

my father was brief, and the results were disastrous.

“You need three full years,” she always told Shane and me. “One year to fall head over heels, one year for all the potential problems to surface, and one year to decide whether those problems are deal breakers or things you can work through.”

If you’re lucky enough to find love, in the first year enjoy the jubilation of romance. It may seem in those early months of the relationship that your partner can do no wrong. You are hopped up on hormones and the exhilaration of exploring something (and someone) new. Enjoy the fireworks and butterflies, but avoid making any major life decisions. Don’t move in together, don’t make any major purchases and don’t start planning the wedding. Do pay attention to your partner’s spending habits, including how cavalierly they whip out their credit card. And do have important conversations about where you see yourself in the future. Do you want to work full time or stay home with the kids? Do you *want* kids? Now is the time to articulate your long-term objectives and see if your partner’s objectives line up with yours. If they don’t, cut your losses before someone gets hurt.

In the second year, the luster of new love starts to wear off. That’s okay—it means you’re seeing who your partner really is, not the idealized version you spent the last year mooning over. When the fireworks fizzle, you’ll begin to notice personality idiosyncrasies and prior baggage that may become problematic down the line. Does she spend money she doesn’t have on junk food and vacations? Is he still paying off his college loans? Worse: Is he completely ignoring his loans as they continue to accumulate interest? Even if it *seemed* like you were in agreement about saving money and paying down debt, actions speak louder than words. Maybe you are suddenly up-front-and-personal with your partner’s issues in a way you never were when you only saw each other once a week. The second year requires greater scrutiny and a more realistic outlook. Your partner isn’t perfect, and neither are you. Now is the time to note each other’s blemishes.

The third year is when you determine whether you can live with a person’s deficiencies and defects. Hopefully, this is still the person